

Coasts

Waves smashing against exposed rocky shores gradually erode the rock to create caves, cliffs, or reefs. The sea sweeps the debris along the coast to more sheltered shores, where it forms shingle banks and sandy beaches. This process is always changing the shape of the coast, carving it away in some places and building it up in others.

▼ COASTLINE
Waves have shaped Byron Bay in eastern Australia into a series of headlands and sandy coves.

WATER



WAVE ENERGY

Breaking waves force water into cracks in coastal rocks. This exerts so much pressure that the rocks can be blown apart. Big chunks fall away near sea level, and this undercuts the rock above so that it eventually collapses into the sea.

SHINGLE AND SAND

The rocks torn away by the waves are tossed around and broken up. The corners are knocked off, creating rounded boulders and shingle. Small fragments become sand and the moving water carries all this debris away. Big, heavy stones are dumped on exposed shores, while fine sand is swept into sheltered bays.

